

motorcycles on the roads in the spring, summer, or fall – you can encounter motorcycles anytime and anywhere. Because we don't see them all year, we may not actively think about them.

Motorcyclists have the same rights and responsibilities as drivers of other vehicles, and must follow the same traffic laws. However, motorcyclists, like pedestrians, bicyclists and skaters, are less visible to drivers. Though you may often see motorcycles on the roads in the spring, summer, or fall – you can encounter motorcycles anytime and anywhere. Because we don't see them all year, we may not actively think about them.

When there is a crash involving a motorcycle and another vehicle, the rider (and passenger) have a much higher chance of being seriously hurt or killed than the driver (and passengers) of the other vehicle. Though motorcyclists are required to wear approved helmets and goggles or a face shield, motorcycles themselves do not offer the rider the protections that you have with other types of vehicles. For example, motorcycles don't protect the rider with a frame around the rider.

Many drivers who are involved in a crash with a motorcyclist report that they did not see the motorcycle. The question is "why not?"

There are several factors that make motorcyclists less visible.

- **Motorcycles, when compared to other highway users, are smaller.** No matter from which direction you view a motorcycle (front, back, or side), you'll find they are smaller than most other highway users.
- **Motorcycles may appear to move faster than other vehicles.** A motorcycle's smaller size makes it seem much farther away, and makes it difficult to judge how far away they are or how fast they are going.
- **Motorcycles may not take up the entire lane because they are not as wide as other vehicles, but an experienced rider may move around within a lane to avoid obstacles, or to help them see better.** In addition to using the full lane, two motorcyclists are allowed to ride side-by-side in a single lane, but a motorcyclist cannot pass or share a

lane with another motor vehicle that is not a motorcycle. If you are overtaking a car/SUV/truck, you might not have seen the motorcycle in front of that vehicle until you're already in the passing lane. The same holds true if you are entering an expressway. You may not see a motorcycle that is driving in the left portion of the lane you intend to merge into.

- **Motorcycle lighting is different, and often less obvious, than other vehicles:**
- **Headlights and taillights on motorcycles must be illuminated when driving.** But, with so many vehicles equipped with daytime running lights (i.e. headlights that are always on – even in daylight), motorcycle headlights don't stand out.
- **It's harder to see the brake lights.** Tail lights on a motorcycle are generally smaller in size than those on other vehicles, and because motorcycle tail lights are always on, the brake lights don't always stand out.
- **Motorcycles don't have a tail light at eye level.** Most cars and trucks are equipped with a "Center High Mount Stop Light" (CHMSL) which is designed to be at, or close to, eye level. Most motorcycle brake lights are mounted lower than eye level, which makes them less obvious to many motorists.
- **Turn signals on motorcycles are often close to the headlight or taillights,** which can make them more difficult to see. Additionally, on most motorcycles, the directional signal does not turn off automatically after a turn, so their turn signal may be on inadvertently when the motorcyclist has no intention of turning.

Intersections can be especially dangerous for motorcycles. It's human nature to notice large vehicles first. Motorcycles are smaller than other vehicles, and they may seem to "blend in." Numbers help tell the story: